

Zara's Back to School Escape

5 clues. 1 padlock. Be ready for the new term.



5 to 15 minute setup

Ages 8 to 13

Print and play

The classroom is locked. Solve five puzzles, crack the code, and open the door before the first day of term.

How to play, and the grown up guide



Detective, listen up. This is your mission. The classroom is locked with a five digit padlock. Each puzzle you solve hands you one digit. Solve all five, write the code, and you crack it open. Work in order, trust the clues, and no peeking at the answer key. Ready? Case open.

SETTING IT UP

Print the pages and go. You can laminate them and use a dry wipe pen so the mission plays again and again. There is nothing to hide and nothing to cut out. Just work through the puzzles in order, one to five.

HOW THE CODE WORKS

Every puzzle gives one number, the digit in the gold box at the bottom of the page. Write each digit in order onto the padlock on the finale page. Five digits, and the classroom door swings open.

GROWN UP TIPS

Read it together. For younger detectives, read each puzzle aloud and let them do the counting and the thinking. For older ones, hand it over and time them. Praise the effort, not just the answer. If they get stuck, point back to Zara's clue rather than giving the digit away. The joy is in the crack, not the copy.

ANSWER KEY • GROWN UPS ONLY

Puzzle 1 Count the supplies = 7 • three pencils, two rubbers, two glue sticks make seven.

Puzzle 2 Crack the word = 6 • the word is PENCIL, which has six letters.

Puzzle 3 Pack the PE bag = 5 • five items belong in the PE bag.

Puzzle 4 The timetable code = 3 • there are three maths lessons in the week.

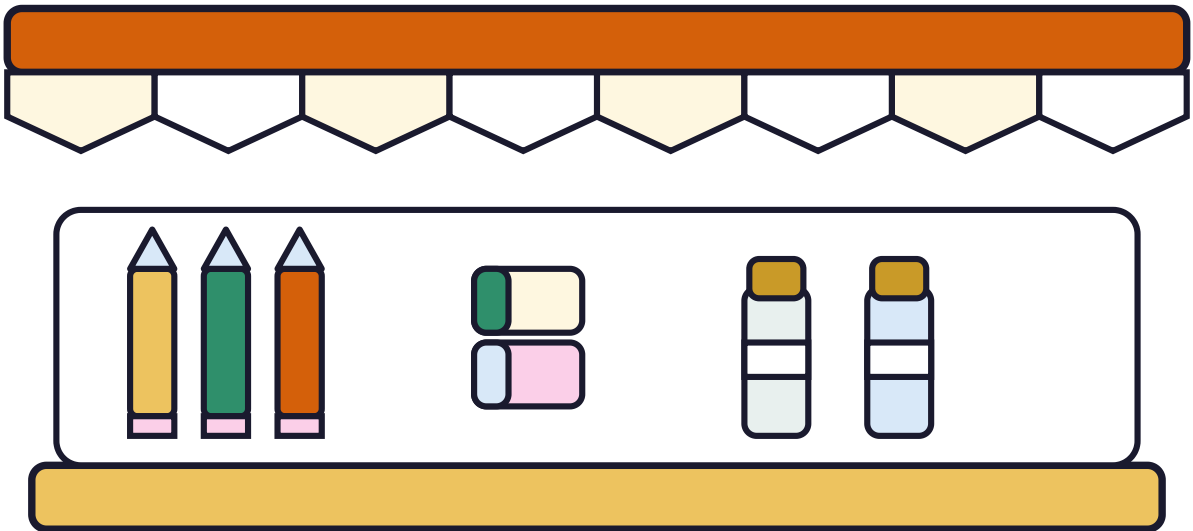
Puzzle 5 Lunch money = 8 • two two pound coins and four one pound coins make eight pounds.

The padlock code is 7 6 5 3 8.

Count the supplies

First stop, the school supplies shop. The shopkeeper has laid everything on the counter. Count every single item on the stall. The total is your first digit. Careful now, detectives count twice.

THE BACK TO SCHOOL STALL



Count the pencils, the rubbers and the glue sticks. How many school supplies are on the stall in total?

My total:

DIGIT 1

Crack the word

Someone has jumbled up the syllables of a back to school word. Put them back in the right order to read the hidden word. Then count the letters. That count is your next digit. This one is a true detective's favourite.

THE JUMBLED SYLLABLES

CIL

+

PEN

Clue from Zara: you write with it, and it lives in your pencil case.

Write the word, one letter per box:

--	--	--	--	--	--

Now count the letters in your word. How many letters are there? That number is your digit.

Letters counted:

--

--

DIGIT 2

Pack the PE bag

It is PE day. Some things belong in the PE bag on the left, and some belong in the school bag on the right. Tick only the things that go in the PE bag. Count your ticks for the next digit.

GOES IN THE PE BAG • TICK THESE



Trainers

☐


Shorts

☐


PE top

☐


Socks

☐


Water bottle

☐

GOES IN THE SCHOOL BAG •
LEAVE THESE



Pencil
case



Reading
book



Lunchbox



Calculator

Count the ticks in the PE bag. How many items belong in the PE bag? That is your digit.

PE items counted:

DIGIT 3

The timetable code

Here is the class timetable for the week. Read it carefully, detective. I need you to find every maths lesson and count them. The number of maths lessons is your fourth digit.

Day	Morning	Afternoon
Monday	Maths	English
Tuesday	Science	Maths
Wednesday	English	PE
Thursday	Maths	Art
Friday	History	Reading

Hunt through every day, morning and afternoon. How many maths lessons are there in the whole week? That count is your digit.

Maths lessons:

DIGIT 4

Lunch money

Last clue, detective. Here is the lunch money in your pocket for the first day. Add up every coin to find the total in pounds. That total is your final digit, and it opens the door.

THE COINS IN YOUR POCKET



Add the two pound coins and the one pound coins together. What is the total in pounds?
That number is your last digit.

Total in pounds: £

DIGIT 5

Open the padlock

Bring your five digits here, in order, one to five. Write the code into the padlock and turn it.



DIGIT 1

DIGIT 2

DIGIT 3

DIGIT 4

DIGIT 5

Case solved, detective!

The classroom door swings open and the new term is ready for you. You spotted every clue, counted true and cracked the code. That is exactly how a Truth Finder thinks. Now walk in tall on the first day. You have got this.

DETECTIVE CERTIFICATE

This certifies that _____ cracked Zara's Back to School Escape and is ready for the new term.